

Rep. Tom Emmer on Squawk Box

CNBC

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****HOST:**

** joining us right now is House Majority Whip Tom Emmer. It's good to see you. We're all trying to understand where this budget reconciliation issue goes, where you think it really stands right now, and what the permutations of this, they might all take, Tom.

****REP. TOM EMMER:**

** Well, good to be with you, Andrew. First off, this all started because we had passed out of the House all 12 appropriations bills, including the DHS, the Department of Homeland Security bill, which has many different parts to it. It was a bicameral, bipartisan, Republicans and Democrats in both the House and the Senate agreed to the bill. It was over in the Senate's jurisdiction, and in the middle of the night, with nobody around, the Senate passed the DHS bill, excluding two pieces of it that relate to Customs and Border Patrol and to the Immigration and Customs Enforcement pieces, and then sent it back to the House. Look, it's not the way we do business, but I think Mick Jagger and the Rolling Stones once said, you don't always get what you want, but sometimes you get what you need, and I think the reconciliation, the budget reconciliation piece that just came over last week is what we need, and we're going to get it passed this week, Andrew.

****ANDREW:**

** What's happening here? I'm just looking, you know, this is what Punchbowl wrote on Friday. They say, Speaker Mike Johnson twice failed in humiliating fashion to pass an extension of FISA, the Controversial Intelligence Surveillance Law, next week. Johnson in the House, GOP will see if the third time is the charm. What's happening right now, just within the party?

****REP. TOM EMMER:**

** Well, it's a completely different topic, but back to the bill that we're going to have to pass to fund all of the Department of Homeland Security. Unfortunately, Democrats refuse to vote for this stuff. They refuse to put American safety first. Instead, they want to put politics first, so we're going to have to do that with Republican votes. And when it comes to what's happening in the Republican Party, it's a great time to be alive and be in this grand party with all these different points of view. This is the way it works. I mean, we started this at the beginning of this Congress with the most narrow majority in the history of Congress, and we have done more in this Congress than majorities of much larger numbers have ever accomplished. So don't underestimate us, Andrew. I think people do this on a regular basis, and I know you've got to put content out there. Our friends here on the Hill got to put content out there that catch people's eyes and get them talking. We'll just keep boring them to death by succeeding.

****ANDREW:**

** Well, let me ask you a different question. Is there any place of overlap between you and the Democrats right now on these issues, where you think you could actually pull some votes?

****REP. TOM EMMER:**

** I think there's a lot. I mean, I think there's a lot of Democrats who are still just left of center. They don't agree on all the policy stuff, but they've got a civil war going on on the other side of the aisle. You've got these progressives that are challenging any candidate who wants to run for office and govern. They just want anarchy on the far left. And look, we've had our issues on the right. They're dealing with theirs on the left. You still have a large group of people here that understand how important FISA, the Section 702 collection is to our military, to our national security. That's on both sides of the aisle. The question is, are they going to be willing to come out against, you know, they've got to stand up and speak out against the radicals in their party, and they've got to do the right thing. Hopefully, you'll see that this week.

****ANDREW:**

** While we have you, the situation in Iran, we keep waiting for some kind of deal to be had. Obviously, Whitkoff and Kushner did not go over there. Now, there's essentially some plan, Axios has reported, has been put out by the Iranians about something around how the strait will be managed. What do you think is sort of an answer that is acceptable to the American people?

****REP. TOM EMMER:**

** Well, the American people, contrary to the polling that I see, I'm getting all kinds of positive feedback about what our president has done. Finally, someone has addressed the organization, Iran, that has killed more Americans than any terrorist group on the face of the planet. And all previous presidents have done is kick this can down the road. This president is dealing with it. You saw that they have long-range capability, at least to hit Western Europe. And if they can do that, they can certainly take the next step. So he's taking care of a threat to the region, to the world, and to everyone here in this country, to our safety. But I think the red line, and I don't know this to be a fact, but you hear the president talk about it all the time, they will not have a nuclear weapon. So this is about the enriched uranium at this point. And if they're not willing to give it up, it's not going to be done. That will be the key. And I mean, you hear the president talking about you got some reasonable people, you got the rumors floating around. I'm not in the intelligence briefing, so this is not coming from classified information. But the mullahs and the Royal Guard seem to be at odds as to how to resolve this matter. That's an issue that they're going to have to take care of. But the red line, I think, for all of us would be they will never have a nuclear weapon.

****JOE:**

** Congressman, I didn't get to say hi. I think I saw you from a distance. 2,600 people. That's a lot of people. Take all night just to do that. But I guess my question revolves around some of the comments the president made, that he had planned to deliver a really scathing takedown of the news media. And he said the events that transpired, there was such a feeling of congeniality and, I don't know, unity, that he said, when we do this again, I would have a much different tone in speech, is what he said. But then he was interviewed on 60 Minutes. And the correspondent decided to read verbatim from the manifesto from this lunatic, the most incendiary part of this individual's, I wouldn't even call them accusations, just the rantings, and just decided to read that. So are we back to another scathing indictment of the press at the next time that he does it again?

****REP. TOM EMMER:**

** I could see how he might go back. And this is the new 60 Minutes. This is the Barry Weiss 60 Minutes. Yeah, his favorite show. Look, Joe, I don't ever expect, the press wants him to go back to that. This is a back and forth that he and the press have had ever since he came down the escalator. So I don't expect that to change. I think

what he was saying the other night, a couple of things. You saw how calm the president was throughout. He came out after, said he wanted to come back and finish the speech because he doesn't want these lunatics, these anti-American freedom of speech people literally trying to disrupt our lives. He's not going to let them win, which is why he wanted to come right back and finish his speech. And then on the tone of the speech, look, Joe, this president has had more assassination attempts, I think, than any other that we know of. One, he knows that it was divine intervention is the reason that he's here. And I think that experience, because he's had it for all of the people in the room, whether he agrees with them, whether he disagrees with them, whether they like him or they have Trump derangement syndrome, they went through something similar the other night. It was a very traumatic event when you hear multiple shots fired and people scrambling and running and diving under their tables. I think the president was throwing out an olive branch about, look, I feel for you people because I know what this feels like.

****JOE:**

** Right. I wonder, in your view, will there be another one in 30 days? It's just hard to you want to come back that night. And I think logistically that that was going to be impossible. It's a crime scene. And it's been hard to carry on, obviously. Is it possible to do it? Will you be back in 30 days if it is going to happen again?

****REP. TOM EMMER:**

** If this is about supporting the First Amendment and freedom of speech, one of the pillars of our free governing society and the president is willing to do it, I'm willing to to support him and be there. I think it'd be great.

****HOST:**

** Majority Whip Tom Emmer. It's always good to see you. Thank you.

****REP. TOM EMMER:**

** Thank you, guys.

This transcript was independently produced by MN-06 Watch for accountability and archival purposes.

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